

ACTOR REHEARSAL SCRIPT

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

. . .

A COMEDY IN THE MAKING

LUIGI PIRANDELLO · TRANS. EDWARD STORER (1922)

REWRITTEN AND DIRECTED BY **KIARASH JAMSHIDI**

VILLAGE PLAYERS, LAUSANNE

Working script for rehearsal. Dialogue, stage directions, and cues only.

All directorial readings, scorings, and production decisions in this edition are the work of Kiarash Jamshidi. Pirandello supplied the play; everything else around it is his.

ACT ONE ONLY

DRAMATIS PERSONÆ

for a nine-performer staging across three stripped settings, with two stage objects in place of two of the children

The Six Characters

THE FATHER

THE MOTHER

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

THE SON

THE BOY

silent — the Boy-chair

THE CHILD

silent — the Child-bundle

MADAME PACE

conjured in Act Two — her own performer

The Village Players — Lausanne

THE MANAGER — HAKIM

PLAYER 1 — PAUL

Leading Man · L'Ingénue · Door-keeper · Machinist · Third Actor

PLAYER 2 — ELENA

Leading Lady · Property Man · Fourth Actor · Second Lady Lead

PLAYER 3 — ARSENI

Juvenile Lead · Prompter · An Actor · Fifth Actor

TWO STAGE OBJECTS, NO PROJECTION

Two of the children are stage objects, not performers, and the script calls them by these names. The **Boy-chair** is a wooden chair with a black coat folded over its back, a schoolboy's cap on the seat, and a small leather satchel at the chair leg. Where the script asks the Step-Daughter to seize the Boy or push him forward, she handles the chair and the coat; where she takes a revolver from his pocket, she takes it from the coat hanging on the chair. The Boy-chair stands at the edge of the stage from the moment the Six walk on; in Act Three the Manager himself moves it behind the fountain basin, and the revolver shot is heard, not seen.

The **Child-bundle** is a small wrapped bundle of white cloth, like a swaddling, with a black silk sash tied around it. It is carried, kissed, set down, and lifted again by the Step-Daughter and the Mother, from the moment the Step-Daughter walks on. It never moves on its own. The drowning at the fountain is hidden by the Step-Daughter bending over the Child-bundle inside the basin; nothing is seen.

There is **no projection, no video, no screen** anywhere in the production. The Step-Daughter's Act Two opening monologue is delivered live, alone in the shower light, with the Child-bundle in her arms and the Boy-chair beside her. At the close of Act Three, as the Son narrates the drowning, the stage lights drop until only the fountain's interior glow and the bare bulb above the Manager's table remain; the Boy-chair is silhouetted behind the basin for ten seconds. Then full blackout. Then the gunshot, from where the Boy-chair is.

Player 1, Player 2, and Player 3 are the working actors of the Village Players company. In this script each is named only as **Player 1**, **Player 2**, or **Player 3** — never by the role they are playing in the moment; the cast list overleaf shows which company roles (Leading Man, Property Man, Prompter, Door-keeper, and so on) each one carries. **Madame Pace** is not a Player function — she is a Character in her own right, carried by her own performer, conjured onto the stage in Act Two; her speeches are tagged simply *Madame Pace*.

DAYTIME · THE STAGE OF A THEATRE

The Comedy is without acts or scenes. The performance is interrupted once, without the curtain being lowered, when the manager and the chief characters withdraw to arrange the scenario. A second interruption of the action takes place when, by mistake, the stage hands let the curtain down.

A C T T H E F I R S T

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The Family — a story walks in off the street and asks to be staged

PART I OF ACT ONE

The Rehearsal

The spectators will find the curtain raised and the stage as it usually is during the day time. It will be half dark, and empty, so that from the beginning the public may have the impression of an impromptu performance. Prompter's box and a small table and chair for the manager.

Two other small tables and several chairs scattered about as during rehearsals.

*The ACTORS and ACTRESSES of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [Il giuoco delle parti.] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. The PROMPTER who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.*

The PLAYERS, some standing, some sitting, chat in two languages and check their phones. One scrolls yesterday's 24 heures; another mutters her lines under her breath. Somebody, in the wings, is making coffee.

Finally, the MANAGER enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. His SECRETARY brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. The PROMPTER takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."

THE MANAGER *[throwing the morning's letters onto the table]*. No. No. Not another one. If it's a bill, a complaint, or a note from somebody with "thoughts about the theatre," burn it before I read it.

PLAYER 2 *[she has been at work an hour; not looking up from her clipboard]*. It's all three, Hakim. The same envelope.

THE MANAGER *[looking round the half-lit room]*. And who opened this room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself, to no one in particular]*. Then for once we are perfectly cast.

THE MANAGER. Save your wit, Paul — leave the words to the author. *[to the Property Man]* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

PLAYER 2 *[a light comes down on to the stage]*. Half light. It's what's left.

THE MANAGER. Half light, half a company, half a budget. *[a beat]* We're ready for Pirandello. *[quietly, almost to himself]* God help us.

THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands]*. Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and play it, this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself]*. The public came back for the third act once.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up]*. For you?

PLAYER 1. It was raining.

PLAYER 2 *[still not looking up]*. Then let's pray for rain.

PLAYER 3 *[reading the "book"]*. "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

THE MANAGER *[to the Property Man]*. Elena — fix up the old red room.

PLAYER 2 *[noting it down]*. The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March.

THE MANAGER. Then make it red.

PLAYER 2. With what, sir? Hope? *[a beat]* Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

PLAYER 3 *[reading from the "book"]*. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook's cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup..."

THE MANAGER *[before anyone can object]*. Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. *[it does not]* Mime them.

PLAYER 1 *[a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line]*. Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. It says so there. *[pointing to the "book"]*

PLAYER 1. But it's *ridiculous*. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up from her clipboard]*. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

THE MANAGER *[rounding on him]*. Ridiculous? Of course it's ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, Paul. Beat the egg. Become the shell.

PLAYER 1. The shell?

THE MANAGER. Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. *[more quietly]* And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us Pirandello — whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?

PLAYER 1. I'd sooner resign.

PLAYER 2. He resigns every Tuesday.

PLAYER 1 [*settling the cook's cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold*]. Let the record show I wear it under protest.

THE MANAGER. The record is noted. The record is always noted. [*clapping*] Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

PLAYER 3. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they've still not mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, Arsenii — in, in. And mind that draught. We can't afford your throat either.

PLAYER 3 [*pausing at the box, half to himself*]. Do we ever rehearse anything real?

THE MANAGER. Real? God forbid. Real things ruin a rehearsal.

The white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The DOOR-KEEPER enters from the stage door carrying the BOY-CHAIR — the black coat over its back, the cap on its seat, the satchel by its leg — sets it at the edge of the stage, and advances towards the Manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the four live CHARACTERS — FATHER, MOTHER, STEP-DAUGHTER, SON — enter, and stop by the door at back of stage. The STEP-DAUGHTER is already carrying the CHILD-BUNDLE.

A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality.

This tenuous light will disappear when they come forward towards the actors. They preserve, however, something of the dream lightness in which they seem almost suspended; but this does not detract from the essential reality of their forms and expressions.

He who is known as THE FATHER is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.

THE MOTHER seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched Boy-chair at the edge of the stage; she shows a lively tenderness for the Child-bundle in her arms.

THE SON (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for THE FATHER, supercilious and indifferent to THE MOTHER. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.

PART II OF ACT ONE

The Arrival

PLAYER 1 [*cap in hand — Player 1's diction still visible underneath*]. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

THE MANAGER [*rudely*]. Eh? What is it?

PLAYER 1 [*timidly — but not without a small lift of the chin*]. These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

THE MANAGER [*without looking up*]. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! [*Turning to the CHARACTERS.*] Who are you, please? What do you want?

THE FATHER [*coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed*]. Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

THE MANAGER [*half angry, half amazed*]. An author? What author?

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

THE MANAGER. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*stepping in front of the Father, taking the line*]. So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

PLAYER 3 [*coming forward from the others*]. Oh — do you hear that?

PLAYER 1 [*stung*]. We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

THE FATHER [*to STEP-DAUGHTER*]. Yes, but if the author isn't here... [*To MANAGER.*] unless you would be willing...

THE MANAGER. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

THE MANAGER. Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

THE FATHER *[stepping closer]*. You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

THE MANAGER. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards. *[The ACTORS, satisfied, applaud their MANAGER.]*

THE FATHER *[cutting across him]*. Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. *[The ACTORS look at one another in amazement.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet, just to the room]*. Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean? A moment ago you were saying the opposite.

THE FATHER. No, sir. I mean only this: you know better than anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible.

THE MANAGER. Very well — but where does all this take us?

THE FATHER. Nowhere — only to show you we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage.

THE MANAGER *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! *[MANAGER and ACTORS burst out laughing; it lands on him — hurt.]* I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

THE MANAGER *[losing patience at last and almost indignant]*. Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! *[To PLAYER 1.]* Paul — for Heaven's sake, turn them out!

THE FATHER *[resisting]*. No, no, look here, we...

THE MANAGER *[roaring]*. We come here to work, you know.

PLAYER 1. One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of.

THE FATHER *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" *[Pointing to the PROMPTER's box.]* which contains us, you refuse to believe...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[advances towards MANAGER, eyes level, not smiling]*. Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir — left stranded halfway.

THE FATHER *[to the Manager]*. Sancho Panza lives. Madame Bovary lives. Their authors died, but they remain. We were born too — but left without a world to hold us.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, to no one in particular]*. He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

THE MANAGER. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

THE FATHER. We want to live.

THE MANAGER. For Eternity?

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

PLAYER 2 *[chin up, the diva back; sotto voce to Player 1]*. They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. *[To the MANAGER.]* But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon arrange it among ourselves.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. But what do you want to arrange? We don't arrange things here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

THE MANAGER. And where is the "book"?

THE FATHER. It is in us! *[The ACTORS laugh.]* The drama is in us, and we are the drama. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[without looking at him]*. His passion. Always the word *passion*. *[crossing behind the Father, voice flat]* My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for him. *[Places a deliberate hand on the FATHER's shoulder, leaves it there one beat too long, withdraws. A single short laugh — no warmth in it.]*

THE FATHER *[angrily]*. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn. [Sings and then dances Valentine — bright, knowing, the smile a fraction too wide. Not a cabaret turn for its own sake but a provocation thrown by someone two months orphaned and lately for sale, daring the room to enjoy her. The audience should laugh, and then, a beat later, wish they had not.]*

*Elle avait de tout p'tits petons, Valentine, Valentine,
elle avait de tout p'tits tétons
que je tâtais à tâtons, ton-ton-tontaine,
elle avait un tout p'tit menton...*

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Bravo! Well done! Encore!

THE MANAGER. Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! *[Turning to the FATHER in consternation.]* Is she mad?

PLAYER 1 *[to Player 2, won over].* She can hold a stage. I'll say that.

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

PART III OF ACT ONE

The Veil

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager].* Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

THE MOTHER *[to the MANAGER; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright].* In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

THE FATHER *[coming forward to support her as do some of the ACTORS].* Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the ACTORS brings a chair, the OTHERS proffer assistance. The MOTHER tries to prevent the FATHER from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

THE MOTHER. No, no; stop it please!

THE FATHER *[raising her veil].* Let them see you!

THE MOTHER *[rising and covering her face with her hands].* I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded].* I don't understand at all. Is this lady your wife? *[To the FATHER.]*

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The ACTORS find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

THE MOTHER *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

THE FATHER. He isn't here — but not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama, sir, lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

| *At the word children, the MOTHER's arm closes around the Child-bundle, before any word comes.*

THE MOTHER. *I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I wanted them? [To the COMPANY.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

THE MOTHER *[her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing]*. Not true? And what can you know about it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To MANAGER.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the SON.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because this man *[Indicates the FATHER.]* forced her to it.

THE MOTHER *[voice tight; eyes still on the floor]*. He forced me to it. *[Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the SON. He does not look back. She lowers them again.]* And I call God to witness it. *[To the MANAGER, still without lifting her head.]* Ask him *[Indicates the FATHER.]* if it isn't true. *Let him speak.* You *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* are not in a position to know anything about it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

THE MOTHER. No, I don't deny it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. *[Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.]* It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

THE MOTHER. Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

PLAYER 1 *[to the COMPANY, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the MOTHER, and the end of the sentence does not arrive].* What a spectacle. What an absolute... *[He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]*

PLAYER 2 *[lower now].* We are the audience this time.

PLAYER 3 *[quietly, the pencil not moving].* For once. *[Nobody laughs.]*

THE MANAGER *[beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward].* Let's hear them out. Listen!

THE SON. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. *[To the MANAGER.]* He mocks me for the phrase I've found to excuse myself with.

THE SON *[without looking up].* Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

THE FATHER. Phrases! And isn't everyone consoled by a word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even remorse. Especially remorse.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No. It took more than words to quiet the remorse in me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the ACTORS.]*

THE SON *[to the STEP-DAUGHTER].* This is vile.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

As the shop is named, the MOTHER draws the Child-bundle up against her and covers its ears with her hand.

THE SON. And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! *[the laugh she means to be ironic does not quite come]*

THE MOTHER *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room].* Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The STEP-DAUGHTER's laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, a screen, and

in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He does.* [*Indicating FATHER.*]

THE MANAGER. I don't understand this at all.

PART IV OF ACT ONE

The Defence

THE FATHER [*he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read*]. Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

THE FATHER. Words are the whole trouble. Each of us carries a whole world inside him, sir; and when I speak, I put my world into the words — and she, listening, fills them with hers. We think we understand each other. We never do. [*A beat. For a moment nobody has an answer to that.*] I say one thing, she hears another — and the explanation becomes another crime.

THE MOTHER [*not loud, not an accusation — the plain fact, set down in the middle of the room*]. But you drove me away. [*A beat. It lands before he can talk over it.*]

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She truly believes it.

THE MOTHER [*looking at the floor between them*]. You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir [*To MANAGER.*] — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

THE FATHER. — it was for your humility that I married you. [*He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.*] You see — she denies it. [*Touche his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.*] She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

PLAYER 2 [*who has been biting her lips with rage at seeing the Leading Man flirting with the Step-Daughter, coming forward to the Manager*]. Hakim — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or not?

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course — but let's hear them out. [*To the FATHER.*] You must please explain yourself quite clearly. [*Sits down.*]

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor clerk, a secretary, full of devotion, who became friends with her. [*Indicating the MOTHER.*] Kindred souls — without the slightest suspicion of evil between them.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess. It reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their exchanging a silent look — how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And that alone kept me in a constant rage. So I sent him away — and then had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master — an animal one has taken in out of pity.

THE MOTHER. Ah yes...

THE FATHER [*suddenly turning to the MOTHER*]. It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

THE MOTHER. He took my son away from me first of all.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*pointing at him, no smile*]. As one can see.

THE FATHER [*quickly*]. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach. [*The Step-Daughter breaks into a laugh at "moral sanity" — sharp, without gaiety. The Father's hand lifts toward the Manager: make her stop.*]

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

PLAYER 1 [*shifting in his seat, eyes down — quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline*]. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

THE FATHER [*a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself*]. Fool! That contradiction, gentlemen, is the proof that I stand here a *live* man before you — exactly this incongruity in my nature has made me suffer. I couldn't live beside that woman [*Indicating the MOTHER.*] any longer; not for the boredom she inspired in me — for the pity I felt for her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*flat, into the room*]. He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

THE MOTHER. And so he turned me out —.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

THE MOTHER. And to free himself.

THE FATHER. Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. [*Beat.*] I did it for her sake more than for mine. [*Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.*] And I never lost sight of you. I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her. [*Points to the Step-Daughter.*]

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*the cleverness drops — just the child she was*]. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*. He used to

follow me in the street. I told my mother, who guessed at once [*The Mother agrees with a nod.*] and wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again, with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers. For me.

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she [*Indicating the Mother.*] went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. Then I was driven — curiosity at first, later something tenderer — toward the family that had come into being through my will.

PLAYER 2 [*the back of a script suddenly being used as a notepad*]. Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

THE MANAGER. A bit discursive this, you know!

THE SON [*turning his face away from the FATHER*]. Literature. Literature.

THE FATHER. This is life, this is passion, sir — but I agree: it is only the part leading up. She [*Pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER.*], as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. — and the skirt down past the knee! [*A beat; she takes the story from him.*] As soon as my father died...

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. [*A small pointing gesture toward the MOTHER, immediately regretted.*] She can barely write her own name — but her daughter could have written a line.

THE MOTHER. And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him — after so many years apart, and all that had happened...

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? I could find no trace of them — and, naturally, my interest dwindled. [*He does not look up.*] Then they came back — and the loneliness still had its grip on me. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. [*A beat. He has to swallow.*] One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. All appear to have the courage to do them though.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have.*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then excuses him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer thing — duty, modesty, shame — nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

THE FATHER [*quietly — for once not defending but attacking, and it is the most dangerous thing he has said all morning*]. Crocodile's tears. How easily she says it. Then ask yourselves, gentlemen, why she guards that one moment of mine so jealously. Because if I am more than that moment — she has to forgive me. And she would rather burn than forgive.

| For a moment — the first — she does not answer. The room waits. Nobody laughs now.

THE MANAGER [*a little too quickly*]. Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you must put into it the reason and sentiment that caused it. I couldn't know that after his death they had come back here, in misery — and that she [*Pointing to the MOTHER.*] had gone to work as a seamstress — in the shop of a certain Madame Pace.

THE MOTHER. You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Poor Mother! Do you know what that woman did, sir? When I brought back the work my mother had finished, she would point out a dress of mine I had torn — and give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid, always I — while this poor creature believed she was sacrificing herself for us, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

THE MANAGER. And one day you met there...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Almost in time.

THE FATHER [*crying out*]. No — in time. *In time*. And I took them back home with me. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

THE FATHER. She wants to nail me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*flat*]. You walked into that room by yourself.

PLAYER 2. Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?

PART V OF ACT ONE

The Hinge

THE SON [*the Father, cornered, has turned to his son — and the room's eyes follow. The Son keeps his hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Don't look at me. I don't come into this.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

THE SON. I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

THE SON [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. You — *you!* I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

THE SON. It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. One day, gentlemen, a young woman of impudent bearing arrives at my home, asking for my father. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there — and asks him for money, in a way that lets one suppose he *must* give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

THE SON. How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

THE SON. How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me? [*the one time the cold cracks*] You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing.

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... [*Pointing out the MOTHER to the MANAGER.*] See, she's crying!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*without looking at the MOTHER*]. Like a fool.

THE FATHER *[indicating Step-Daughter]*. She can't stand him, you know. *[Then referring again to the Son.]* He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. *[In confidence.]* The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

THE MANAGER. Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

THE FATHER. The little girl vanishes first. Then the boy. Then she runs. And what remains? Three people in the same house, unable to belong to one another. A family, perhaps — but without faith, without warmth, without any place where happiness could take root.

PART VI OF ACT ONE

The Bargain

THE MANAGER. Damn it... there is something in what you say. I don't like it, but it interests me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[coming forward]*. When you've got a character like me.

THE FATHER *[shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the MANAGER]*. You be quiet!

THE MANAGER *[reflecting]*. It's new... hem... yes... You've got a nerve, though — to come here and fling it at me like this.

THE FATHER. You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

THE MANAGER. Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

THE FATHER. No, sir. We do not act like amateurs. We live the roles life has cast us in.

THE MANAGER. Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

THE FATHER. No, no. Look here! You must be the author. You need not invent us — only give us form.

THE MANAGER. I? What are you talking about?

THE FATHER. Yes, you, you! Why not?

THE MANAGER. Because I have never been an author: that's why.

THE FATHER. Then become one now — not by inventing, sir, but by listening. We are already here. You need only take us down.

THE MANAGER. It won't do.

THE FATHER. What? When you see us live our drama...

THE MANAGER. Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

THE FATHER. No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

THE MANAGER. Well... It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

THE FATHER. Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

THE MANAGER *[he is hooked, in spite of himself].* God help me, it tempts me. I ought to throw you out — and instead I want to see the first scene. Come to my office. We'll see what can be done.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[level].* Extraordinary, yes — if he does not get to tell it alone.

THE FATHER. They *[Indicating the CHARACTERS.]* had better come with us too, hadn't they?

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes. Come on! come on! *[Moves away and then turning to the ACTORS.]* Be punctual, please! *[MANAGER and the Six CHARACTERS cross the stage and go off. The other ACTORS remain, looking at one another in astonishment.]*

PLAYER 1. Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

PLAYER 3. They are not ordinary strangers.

PLAYER 2. No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

PLAYER 1. And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

PLAYER 3. Perhaps there is a play.

PLAYER 2. There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER) *[the cap forgotten in his hand; Player 1's posture leaking through the doorman's apology].* I only let them in.

PLAYER 2. That is not a defence.

PLAYER 1. They looked expected.

PLAYER 3. Am I taking this down?

PLAYER 2. Take everything down, Arsenii. It may be evidence.

Thus talking, the ACTORS leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back; others retiring to their dressing-rooms.

✦

— *End of Act I* —

The interval — about twenty minutes, and the production's only one. *The chair-circle is struck and the two-level set of Act Two built behind the curtain. From the top of Act Two the play runs unbroken to the end: Act Three follows Act Two behind the dropped curtain, with no second interval, so the whole second half builds in one sweep to the fountain.*

C O L O P H O N

This is a director's edition rewritten and directed by Kiarash Jamshidi. All directorial readings, scorings, adaptations, and production decisions in this edition — the chair-and-coat and the Child-bundle, the four-stage Father arc, the Step-Daughter's three cuts, the Mother's three silences, the Manager as audience-symbol, the Madame Pace arc from comic to chilling, the Lausanne anchoring, the rehearsal schedule, the Light & Sound score, and every part-note throughout — are his own work.

*Underlying play: Luigi Pirandello, *Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore* (1921), in the public-domain Edward Storer English translation (1922). Source text: Project Gutenberg Australia, eBook No. 0608521h.html (November 2006).*

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